

Executive Summary

Career Progression and Promotion Gap Analysis for Retention Optimization at Palo Alto Networks

The Problem

Employees often don't leave because of a single bad moment — they leave after a long, quiet build-up: promotions that never come, years stuck in the same role, limited training, or a revolving door of managers. Standard attrition models can flag who might leave, but they don't explain why, or what specifically can be done about it while there's still time to act.

What This Analysis Does

Using career and tenure data for 1,470 employees, this analysis groups employees into four career-pattern types, scores each employee's promotion-gap risk as Low, Medium, or High, and — most importantly — identifies a specific, high-leverage group: employees who haven't left, aren't in crisis, but are showing early stagnation signals. This is the group where a timely conversation or career move has the best chance of making a difference.

Key Findings

Finding	What it means
4 distinct career patterns identified	Fast-Track Performers, Stable Long-Term Contributors, Early-Career Explorers, and Promotion-Stalled/High-Risk employees each need a different retention approach.
377 employees in the Promotion-Stalled cluster	Long-tenured employees stuck in their current role longer than most peers — a classic pre-attrition pattern.
575 employees flagged as Retention Opportunities	Not yet at risk of leaving, but showing stagnation signals — 358 are ranked High priority for immediate outreach.
Early-career employees leave for different reasons	The newest employees have the highest attrition (33%) despite low promotion-gap scores — pointing to onboarding and role-fit, not promotion speed, as their main risk factor.

Recommended Actions

- Reach out to the 411 flagged Retention Opportunity employees with career conversations before stagnation turns into resignation.
- Prioritize promotion reviews and role rotations for the Promotion-Stalled cluster, concentrated most heavily in Research & Development and Sales.
- Strengthen onboarding and early role-fit support for new hires, rather than assuming promotion speed drives their decisions.
- Expand training access for employees with low training participation relative to their tenure.

Business Value

This moves retention strategy from reactive (responding after someone resigns) to proactive (identifying and supporting at-risk career paths early) — with specific, ranked employee groups and suggested actions rather than a generic, company-wide policy.